
BUYER TIP 1
BUYING? KNOW YOUR REAL PAYMENT.
THE PRICE ISN'T YOUR PAYMENT
Your monthly cost is the loan payment plus property taxes, homeowner's insurance, and any mortgage insurance or HOA dues. Here's how I recommend budgeting for all of it before you tour.
BUYER TIPS
1 / 10 · SWIPE →

THE MARKET

NC + SC RIGHT NOW

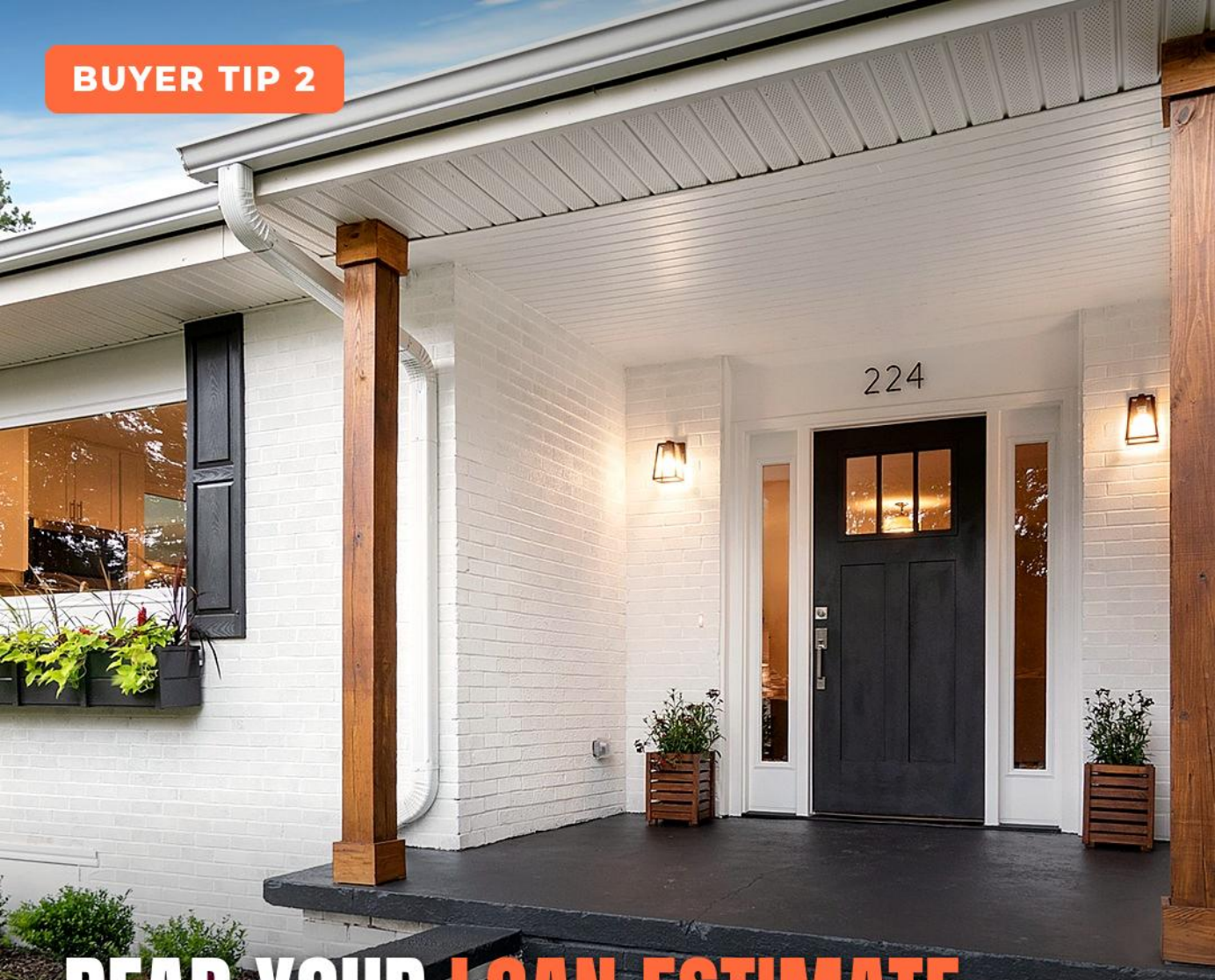
SEPT 2026 · MEDIAN LIST + ACTIVE

MECKLENBURG NC	$444,750	−6.4% YoY
ACTIVE	4,389	+16.8% YoY
YORK SC	$419,972	−0.8% YoY
ACTIVE	1,201	+9.7% YoY

More homes to choose from than a year ago. That gives you room to compare the full monthly cost, not just the price.

Source: Realtor.com Economic Research, county data, Sep 2026

BUYER TIP 2



READ YOUR LOAN ESTIMATE

- Your lender must send it within 3 business days of your application
- It shows the estimated rate, monthly payment, closing costs, and estimated taxes and insurance
- Every lender uses the same form, so you can compare offers side by side

BUYER TIP 3



TAXES AND INSURANCE CAN CHANGE

- Many lenders collect them through an escrow account, as part of your monthly payment
- Property taxes and insurance premiums can change from year to year, and your payment changes with them
- Ask for the current tax bill and get an insurance quote before you make an offer

BUYER TIP 4



PLAN FOR MORTGAGE INSURANCE

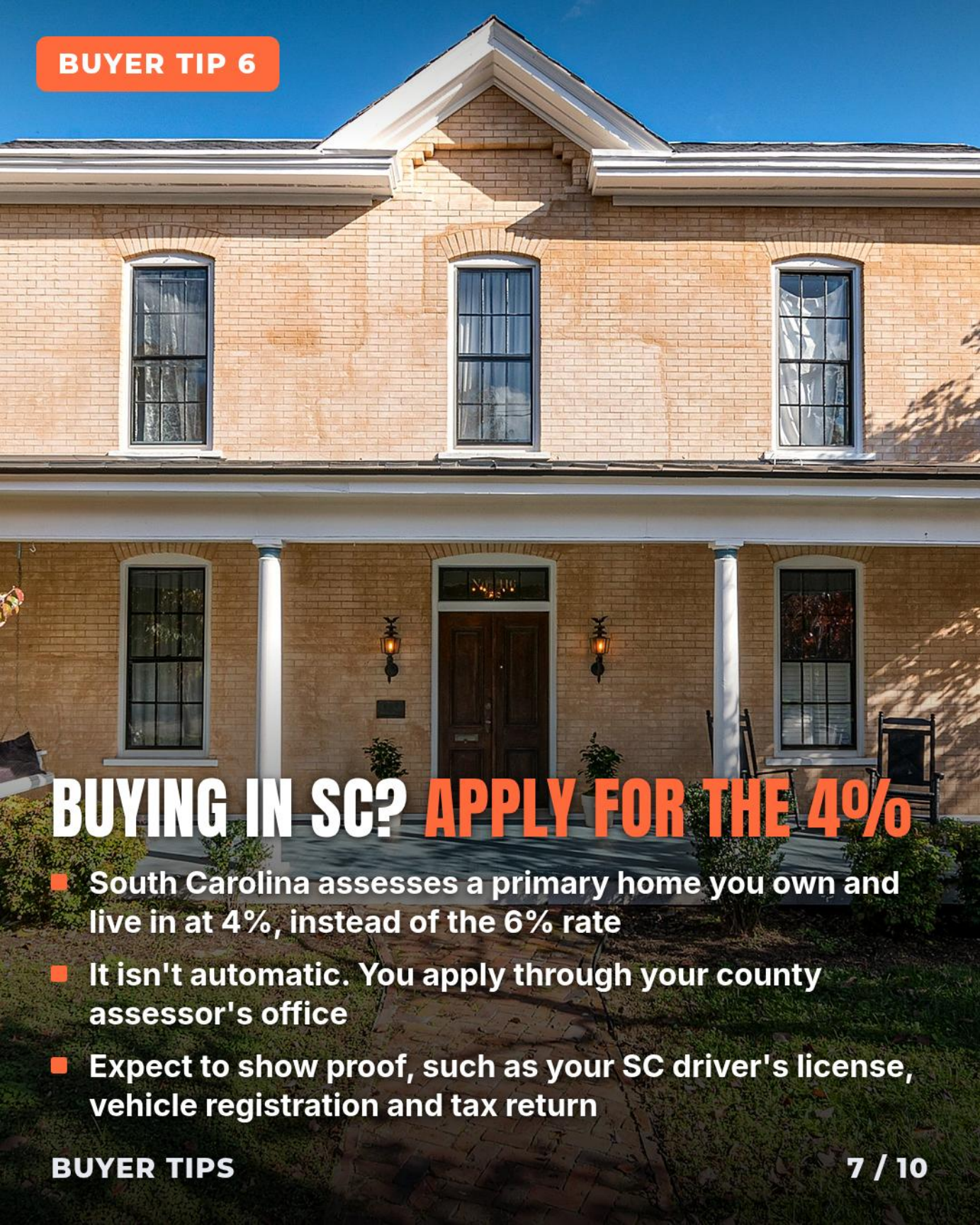
- A conventional loan with less than 20% down may require private mortgage insurance (PMI)
- You can ask in writing to cancel it once your balance is scheduled to reach 80% of the home's original value
- It generally ends automatically at 78% if you're current. FHA and VA loans follow different rules

BUYER TIP 5



ASK ABOUT HOA DUES

- Ask what the dues are, how often they're billed and what they cover
- Ask whether any special assessments are planned
- Ask whether dues are paid with your mortgage or straight to the association, so nothing gets missed



BUYER TIP 6

BUYING IN SC? APPLY FOR THE 4%

- South Carolina assesses a primary home you own and live in at 4%, instead of the 6% rate
- It isn't automatic. You apply through your county assessor's office
- Expect to show proof, such as your SC driver's license, vehicle registration and tax return

BUYER TIP 7



BUDGET FOR UTILITIES AND UPKEEP

- Ask the seller for typical monthly utility bills
- Set aside money each month for maintenance and repairs
- Your inspection report can show what may need attention first

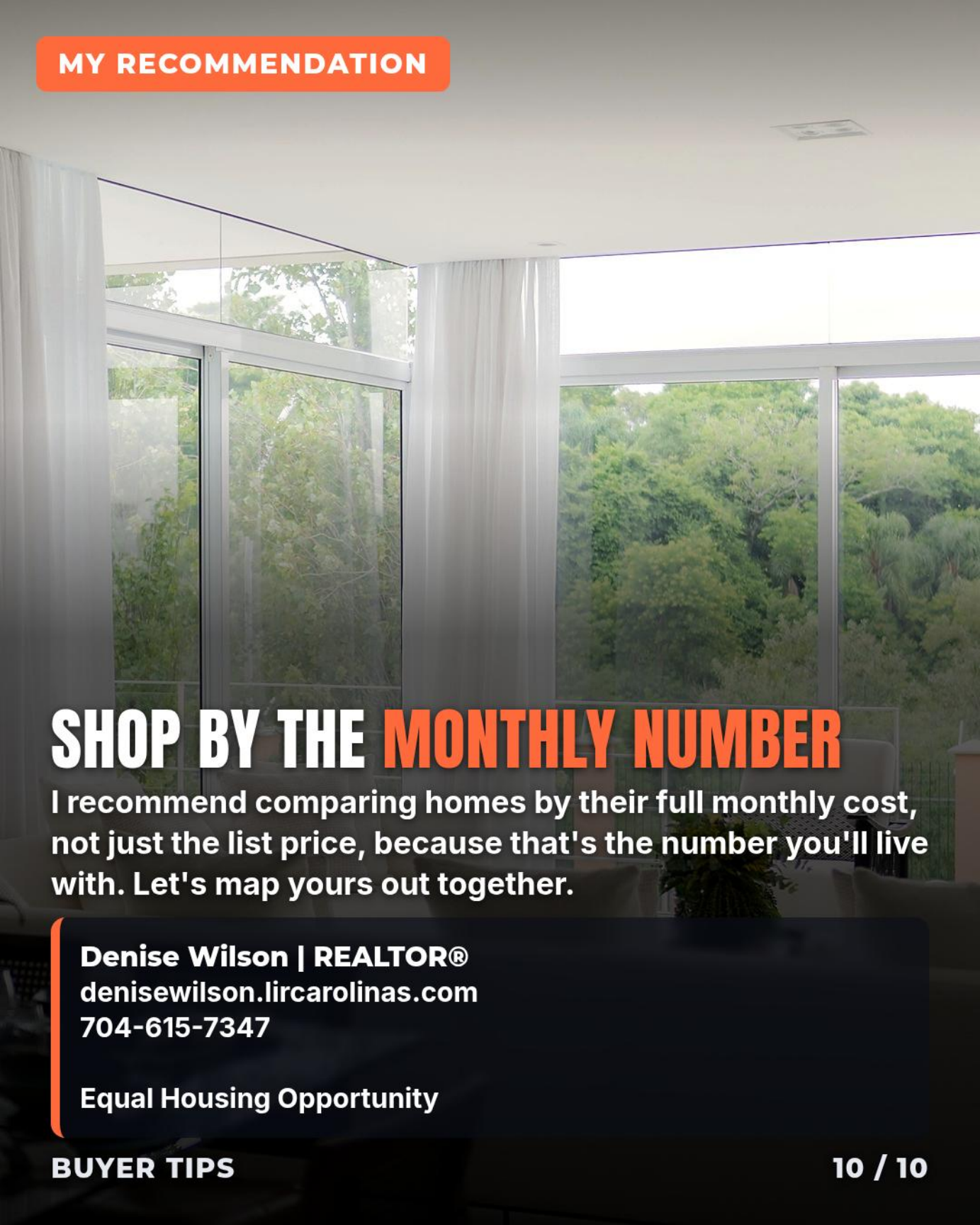
BUYER TIP 8



LEAVE ROOM IN YOUR BUDGET

- Your preapproval shows what a lender may lend, not the payment that feels comfortable to you
- Pick a monthly number that still leaves room for savings
- Keep some cash in reserve after closing for the unexpected

MY RECOMMENDATION



SHOP BY THE MONTHLY NUMBER

I recommend comparing homes by their full monthly cost, not just the list price, because that's the number you'll live with. Let's map yours out together.

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Equal Housing Opportunity